

Project Brief

Project: UniLink – ABC University Student Enquiry and Appointment System

Client: Student Services Division, ABC University Central Administration

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Date: 25 June 2025

Background

The Student Services Division receives a high volume of student enquiries across various channels including email, phone, and walk-ins. These requests are currently handled manually and tracked using spreadsheets, resulting in delays, inconsistent communication, and limited visibility. The proposed UniLink system aims to centralize enquiry management and streamline appointment scheduling and management through a simple digital platform supported by AI features.

Objectives

- Develop a centralized platform for handling student enquiries
- Streamline appointment scheduling and management
- Improve the timeliness and consistency of responses to student queries
- Reduce workload on staff
- Enhance reporting and analysis for managerial oversight

Project Scope

- A web-based enquiry submission and management
- Automated classification and prioritization of enquiry types
- Automated routing of enquiries to relevant service teams
- Integrated appointment booking with staff availability
- A centralized depository of previous enquiries and internal documents with basic searching
- Dashboard for staff to manage and respond to enquiries
- A chatbot to answer frequently asked questions and guide students through enquiry categories
- Analytics dashboard for tracking enquiry trends and service performance

Stakeholders

- Administrative Officers:
 - Log and triage all incoming enquiries
 - Resolve general enquiries
 - Assign complex enquiries to appropriate Student Support Officers

- Student Support Officers:
 - Respond to and resolve assigned complex enquiries
 - Escalate unresolved issues to the Manager
 - Record outcomes and communications in the tracking system
- Manager, Student Support Services:
 - Oversee performance and resolution quality
 - Approve policy exceptions
 - Handle escalated enquiries
 - Generate monthly service reports for Director review
- Students
 - Submit enquiries
 - Manage their own enquiries
 - Provide feedback after service
- Director of Student Support and Services (Helen)
 - Define or revise policy or strategies based on the performance report
- University IT Support team
 - Support system deployment, integration and maintenance

Constraints

- The system must comply with data privacy and ethical AI use and governance guidelines
- Development and deployment will be limited to internal university resources
- Interfaces must be designed for both desktop and mobile use, ensuring usability across devices

Assumptions

- All service units will cooperate and provide access to existing enquiry data
- Staff will be trained to use the new system before rollout
- Initial integration with existing systems will be limited to Outlook calendar of Student Service Officers
- Adequate funding and technical support will be available throughout the development lifecycle
- Students will continue using email and web forms as the primary enquiry channels during transition

Risks

- Resistance from staff accustomed to manual processes may hinder adoption
- Risks associated with the use of AI
- Delays in integrating calendars or legacy systems could impact booking functionalities
- Handling student data may introduce privacy and cybersecurity concerns.

- Transitioning from legacy spreadsheets/manual systems to digital records could cause data loss or errors.

Business Case

Implementing the UniLink Enquiry and Appointment System will provide immediate operational improvements in managing routine student support tasks. Staff efficiency and response accuracy are expected to increase, while students will benefit from more timely and organized service. This focused, low-complexity project also serves as a foundation for future digital transformation initiatives.